

excited the curiosity of the man, and it was not surprising that he allowed some of the feelings which agitated his mind to appear in his face. Athos closed the doors carefully, confiding the keys to Grimaud, who had chosen his domicile beneath the shed itself, which led to the cellar where the casks had been deposited. The sergeant escorted the Comte de la Fère to the camp. There a fresh guard awaited him, and relieved the four men who had conducted Athos.

This fresh guard was commanded by the aid-de-camp Digby, who, on their way, fixed upon Athos looks so little encouraging, that the Frenchman asked himself whence arose, with regard to him, this vigilance and this severity, when the evening before he had been left perfectly free. He nevertheless continued his way to the headquarters, keeping to himself the observations which men and things forced him to make. He found in the general's tent, to which he had been introduced the evening before, three superior officers: these were Monk's lieutenant and two colonels. Athos perceived his sword; it was still on the table where he left it. Neither of the officers had seen Athos, consequently neither of them knew him. Monk's lieutenant asked, at the appearance of Athos, if that were the same gentleman with whom the general had left the tent.

'Yes, your honour,' said the sergeant, 'it is the same.'

'But,' said Athos, haughtily, 'I do not deny it, I think; and now, gentlemen, in turn, permit me to ask you to what purpose these questions are asked, and particularly some explanations upon the tone in which you ask them?'

'Monsieur,' said the lieutenant, 'if we address these questions to you, it is because we have a right to do so, and if we make them in a particular tone, it is because that tone, believe me, agrees with the circumstances.'

'Gentlemen,' said Athos, 'you do not know who I am; but I must tell you that I acknowledge no one here but General Monk as my equal. Where is he? Let me be conducted to him, and if he has any questions to put to me, I will answer him and to his satisfaction, I hope. I repeat, gentlemen, where is the general?'

'Eh! good God! you know better than we do where he is,' said the lieutenant.

'I?' 'Yes, you.'

'Monsieur,' said Athos, 'I do not understand you.'

'You will understand me—and, in the first place, do not speak so loudly.'

Athos smiled disdainfully.

'We don't ask you to smile,' said one of the colonels warmly; 'we require you to answer.'

'And I, gentlemen, declare to you that I will not reply until I am in the presence of the general.'

'But,' replied the same colonel who had already spoken, 'you know very well that is impossible.'

'This is the second time I have received this strange reply to the wish I express,' said Athos. 'Is the general absent?'

This question was made with such apparent good faith, and the gentleman wore an air of such natural surprise, that the three officers exchanged a meaning look. The lieutenant, by a tacit convention with the other two, was spokesman.

'Monsieur, the general left you last night on the borders of the monastery.'

'Yes, monsieur.'

'And you went—'

'It is not for me to answer you, but for those who have accompanied me. They were your soldiers, ask them.'

'But if we please to question you?'

'Then it will please me to reply, monsieur, that I do not recognize any one here, that I know no one here but the general, and that it is to him alone I will reply.'

'So be it, monsieur; but as we are the masters, we constitute ourselves a council of war, and when you are before judges you must reply.'

The countenance of Athos expressed nothing but astonishment and disdain, instead of the terror the officers expected to read in it at this threat.

'Scottish or English judges upon me, a subject of the king of France; upon me, placed under the safeguard of British honour! You are mad, gentlemen!' said Athos, shrugging his shoulders.

The officers looked at each other. 'Then, monsieur,' said one of them, 'do you pretend not to know where the general is?'

'To that, monsieur, I have already replied.'

‘Yes, but you have already replied an incredible thing.’

‘It is true, nevertheless, gentlemen. Men of my rank are not generally liars. I am a gentleman. I have told you, and when I have at my side the sword which, by an excess of delicacy, I left last night upon the table whereon it still lies, believe me, no man says that to me which I am unwilling to hear. I am at this moment disarmed; if you pretend to be my judges, try me; if you are but my executioners, kill me.’

‘But, monsieur—’ asked the lieutenant, in a more courteous voice, struck with the lofty coolness of Athos.

‘Sir, I came to speak confidentially with your general about affairs of importance. It was not an ordinary welcome that he gave me. The accounts your soldiers can give you may convince you of that. If, then, the general received me in that manner, he knew my titles to his esteem. Now, you do not suspect, I should think, that I should reveal my secrets to you, and still less his.’

‘But these casks, what do they contain?’

‘Have you not put that question to your soldiers? What was their reply?’

‘That they contained powder and ball.’

‘From whom had they that information? They must have told you that.’

‘From the general; but we are not dupes.’

‘Beware, gentlemen; it is not to me you are now giving the lie, it is to your leader.’

The officers again looked at each other. Athos continued: ‘Before your soldiers the general told me to wait a week, and at the expiration of that week he would give me the answer he had to make me. Have I fled away? No; I wait.’

‘He told you to wait a week!’ cried the lieutenant.

‘He told me that so clearly, sir, that I have a sloop at the mouth of the river, which I could with ease have joined yesterday, and embarked. Now, if I have remained, it was only in compliance with the desire of your general; his honour having requested me not to depart without a last audience, which he fixed at a week hence. I repeat to you, then, I am waiting.’

Chapter XXVIII

The Next Day



It was seven o'clock in the morning, the first rays of day lightened the pools of the marsh, in which the sun was reflected like a red ball, when Athos, awakening and opening the window of his bed-chamber, which looked out upon the banks of the river, perceived, at fifteen paces' distance from him, the sergeant and the men who had accompanied him the evening before, and who, after having deposited the casks at his house, had returned to the camp by the causeway on the right.

Why had these men come back after having returned to the camp? That was the question which first presented itself to Athos. The sergeant, with his head raised, appeared to be watching the moment when the gentleman should appear to address him. Athos, surprised to see these men, whom he had seen depart the night before, could not refrain from expressing his astonishment to them.

‘There is nothing surprising in that, monsieur,’ said the sergeant; ‘for yesterday the general commanded me to watch over your safety, and I thought it right to obey that order.’

‘Is the general at the camp?’ asked Athos.

‘No doubt he is, monsieur; as when he left you he was going back.’

‘Well, wait for me a moment; I am going thither to render an account of the fidelity with which you fulfilled your duty, and to get my sword, which I left upon the table in the tent.’

‘This happens very well,’ said the sergeant, ‘for we were about to request you to do so.’

Athos fancied he could detect an air of equivocal bonhomie upon the countenance of the sergeant; but the adventure of the vault might have

The lieutenant turned towards the other officers, and said, in a low voice: 'If this gentleman speaks truth, there may still be some hope. The general may be carrying out some negotiations so secret, that he thought it imprudent to inform even us. Then the time limited for his absence would be a week.' Then, turning towards Athos: 'Monsieur,' said he, 'your declaration is of the most serious importance; are you willing to repeat it under the seal of an oath?'

'Sir,' replied Athos, 'I have always lived in a world where my simple word was regarded as the most sacred of oaths.'

'This time, however, monsieur, the circumstance is more grave than any you may have been placed in. The safety of the whole army is at stake. Reflect; the general has disappeared, and our search for him has been in vain. Is this disappearance natural? Has a crime been committed? Are we not bound to carry our investigations to extremity? Have we any right to wait with patience? At this moment, everything, monsieur, depends upon the words you are about to pronounce.'

'Thus questioned, gentlemen, I no longer hesitate,' said Athos. 'Yes, I came hither to converse confidentially with General Monk, and ask him for an answer regarding certain interests; yes, the general being, doubtless, unable to pronounce before the expected battle, begged me to remain a week in the house I inhabit, promising me that in a week I should see him again. Yes, all this is true, and I swear it by God who is the absolute master of my life and yours.' Athos pronounced these words with so much grandeur and solemnity, that the three officers were almost convinced. Nevertheless, one of the colonels made a last attempt.

'Monsieur,' said he, 'although we may now be persuaded of the truth of what you say, there is yet a strange mystery in all this. The general is too prudent a man to have thus abandoned his army on the eve of a battle without having at least given notice of it to one of us. As for myself, I cannot believe but some strange event has been the cause of this disappearance. Yesterday some foreign fishermen came to sell their fish here; they were lodged yonder among the Scots; that is to say, on the road the general took with this gentleman, to go to the Abbey, and to return from it. It was one of these fishermen that accompanied the general with a light. And this morning, bark and fishermen have all disappeared, carried away by the night's tide.'

‘For my part,’ said the lieutenant, ‘I see nothing in that that is not quite natural, for these people were not prisoners.’

‘No; but I repeat it was one of them who lighted the general and this gentleman to the Abbey, and Digby assures us that the general had strong suspicions concerning those people. Now, who can say whether these people were not connected with this gentleman, and that, the blow being struck, the gentleman, who is evidently brave, did not remain to reassure us by his presence, and to prevent our researches being made in a right direction?’

This speech made an impression upon the other two officers.

‘Sir,’ said Athos, ‘permit me to tell you, that your reasoning, though specious in appearance, nevertheless wants consistency, as regards me. I have remained, you say, to divert suspicion. Well! on the contrary, suspicions arise in me as well as in you; and I say, it is impossible, gentlemen, that the general, on the eve of a battle, should leave his army without saying anything to at least one of his officers. Yes, there is some strange event connected with this; instead of being idle and waiting, you must display all the activity and all the vigilance possible. I am your prisoner, gentlemen, upon parole or otherwise. My honour is concerned in ascertaining what has become of General Monk, and to such a point, that if you were to say to me, “Depart!” I should reply: “No, I will remain!” And if you were to ask my opinion, I should add: “Yes, the general is the victim of some conspiracy, for, if he had intended to leave the camp he would have told me so.” Seek, then, search the land, search the sea; the general has not gone of his own good will.’

The lieutenant made a sign to the two other officers.

‘No, monsieur,’ said he, ‘no; in your turn you go too far. The general has nothing to suffer from these events, and, no doubt, has directed them. What Monk is now doing he has often done before. We are wrong in alarming ourselves; his absence will, doubtless, be of short duration; therefore, let us beware, lest by a pusillanimity which the general would consider a crime, of making his absence public, and by that means demoralize the army. The general gives a striking proof of his confidence in us; let us show ourselves worthy of it. Gentlemen, let the most profound silence cover all this with an impenetrable veil; we will detain this gentleman, not from mistrust of him with regard to the crime, but to assure more

‘Hush! monsieur, it is agreed that we shall speak no more of that.’ And bowing to Athos, he went up the stairs, meeting about half-way his men, who were coming down. He had not gone twenty paces, when a faint but prolonged whistle was heard at a distance. Monk listened, but seeing nothing and hearing nothing, he continued his route. Then he remembered the fisherman, and looked about for him; but the fisherman had disappeared. If he had, however, looked with more attention, he might have seen that man, bent double, gliding like a serpent along the stones and losing himself in the mist that floated over the surface of the marsh. He might equally have seen, had he attempted to pierce that mist, a spectacle that might have attracted his attention; and that was the rigging of the vessel, which had changed place, and was now nearer the shore. But Monk saw nothing, and thinking he had nothing to fear, he entered the deserted causeway which led to his camp. It was then that the disappearance of the fisherman appeared strange, and that a real suspicion began to take possession of his mind. He had just placed at the orders of Athos the only post that could protect him. He had a mile of causeway to traverse before he could regain his camp. The fog increased with such intensity that he could scarcely distinguish objects at ten paces’ distance. Monk then thought he heard the sound of an oar over the marsh on the right. ‘Who goes there?’ said he.

But nobody answered; then he cocked his pistol, took his sword in his hand, and quickened his pace, without, however, being willing to call anybody. Such a summons, for which there was no absolute necessity, appeared unworthy of him.

'Very well.'

'What shall I do with the horse, general.'

'Look here.'

The sergeant descended the three steps which separated him from Monk, and came into the vault.

'You see,' said Monk, 'that gentleman yonder?'

'Yes, general.'

'And you see these two casks?'

'Perfectly.'

'They are two casks, one containing powder, and the other balls; I wish these casks to be transported to the little hamlet at the mouth of the river, and which I intend to occupy to-morrow with two hundred muskets. You understand that the commission is a secret one, for it is a movement that may decide the fate of the battle.'

'Oh, general!' murmured the sergeant.

'Mind, then! Let these casks be fastened on to the horse, and let them be escorted by two men and you to the residence of this gentleman, who is my friend. But take care that nobody knows it.'

'I would go by the marsh if I knew the road,' said the sergeant.

'I know one myself,' said Athos; 'it is not wide, but it is solid, having been made upon piles; and with care we shall get over safely enough.'

'Do everything this gentleman shall order you to do.'

'Oh! oh! the casks are heavy,' said the sergeant, trying to lift one.

'They weigh four hundred pounds each, if they contain what they ought to contain, do they not, monsieur.'

'Thereabouts,' said Athos.

The sergeant went in search of the two men and the horse. Monk, left alone with Athos, affected to speak to him on nothing but indifferent subjects while examining the vault in a cursory manner. Then, hearing the horse's steps,—

'I leave you with your men, monsieur,' said he, 'and return to the camp. You are perfectly safe.'

'I shall see you again, then, my lord?' asked Athos.

'That is agreed upon, monsieur, and with much pleasure.'

Monk held out his hand to Athos.

'Ah! my lord, if you would!' murmured Athos.

effectively the secret of the general's absence by keeping among ourselves; therefore, until fresh orders, the gentleman will remain at headquarters.'

'Gentlemen,' said Athos, 'you forget that last night the general confided to me a deposit over which I am bound to watch. Give me whatever guard you like, chain me if you like, but leave me the house I inhabit for my prison. The general, on his return, would reproach you, I swear on the honour of a gentleman, for having displeased him in this.'

'So be it, monsieur,' said the lieutenant; 'return to your abode.'

Then they placed over Athos a guard of fifty men, who surrounded his house, without losing sight of him for a minute.

The secret remained secure, but hours, days passed away without the general's returning, or without anything being heard of him.

Monk surprised this flash, and immediately extinguished it by one of those silent smiles which always caused his interlocutors to know they had made no inroad on his mind.

‘Then, my lord, it is a week that you desire me to wait?’

‘A week? yes, monsieur.’

‘And during those days what shall I do?’

‘If there should be a battle, keep at a distance from it, I beseech you. I know the French delight in such amusements;—you might take a fancy to see how we fight, and you might receive some chance shot. Our Scotsmen are very bad marksmen, and I do not wish that a worthy gentleman like you should return to France wounded. Nor should I like to be obliged, myself, to send to your prince his million left here by you; for then it would be said, and with some reason, that I paid the Pretender to enable him to make war against the parliament. Go, then, monsieur, and let it be done as has been agreed upon.’

‘Ah, my lord,’ said Athos, ‘what joy it would give me to be the first that penetrated to the noble heart which beats beneath that cloak!’

‘You think, then, that I have secrets,’ said Monk, without changing the half cheerful expression of his countenance. ‘Why, monsieur, what secret can you expect to find in the hollow head of a soldier? But it is getting late, and our torch is almost out; let us call our man.’

‘*Hola!*’ cried Monk in French, approaching the stairs; ‘hola! fisherman!’

The fisherman, benumbed by the cold night air, replied in a hoarse voice, asking what they wanted of him.

‘Go to the post,’ said Monk, ‘and order a sergeant, in the name of General Monk, to come here immediately.’

This was a commission easily performed; for the sergeant, uneasy at the general’s being in that desolate Abbey, had drawn nearer by degrees, and was not much further off than the fisherman. The general’s order was therefore heard by him, and he hastened to obey it.

‘Get a horse and two men,’ said Monk.

‘A horse and two men?’ repeated the sergeant.

‘Yes,’ replied Monk. ‘Have you got any means of getting a horse with a pack-saddle or two panniers?’

‘No doubt, at a hundred paces off, in the Scottish camp.’

'I shall give orders to have these two casks transported whither you please. Where are you lodging, monsieur?'

'In a little hamlet at the mouth of the river, your honour.'

'Oh, I know the hamlet; it consists of five or six houses, does it not?'

'Exactly. Well, I inhabit the first,—two net-makers occupy it with me; it is their bark which brought me ashore.'

'But your own vessel, monsieur?'

'My vessel is at anchor, a quarter of a mile at sea, and waits for me.'

'You do not think, however, of setting out immediately?'

'My lord, I shall try once more to convince your honour.'

'You will not succeed,' replied Monk; 'but it is of consequence that you should depart from Newcastle without leaving of your passage the least suspicion that might prove injurious to me or you. To-morrow my officers think Lambert will attack me. I, on the contrary, am convinced he will not stir; it is in my opinion impossible. Lambert leads an army devoid of homogeneous principles, and there is no possible army with such elements. I have taught my soldiers to consider my authority subordinate to another, therefore, after me, round me, and beneath me, they still look for something. It would result that if I were dead, whatever might happen, my army would not be demoralized all at once; it results, that if I choose to absent myself, for instance, as it does please me to do sometimes, there would not be in the camp the shadow of uneasiness or disorder. I am the magnet—the sympathetic and natural strength of the English. All those scattered irons that will be sent against me I shall attract to myself. Lambert, at this moment, commands eighteen thousand deserters; but I have never mentioned that to my officers, you may easily suppose. Nothing is more useful to an army than the expectation of a coming battle; everybody is awake—everybody is on guard. I tell you this that you may live in perfect security. Do not be in a hurry, then, to cross the seas; within a week there will be something fresh, either a battle or an accommodation. Then, as you have judged me to be an honourable man, and confided your secret to me, I have to thank you for this confidence, and I shall come and pay you a visit or send for you. Do not go before I send word. I repeat the request.'

'I promise you, general,' cried Athos, with a joy so great, that in spite of all his circumspection, he could not prevent its sparkling in his eyes.

Chapter XXVIII

Smuggling



Two days after the events we have just related, and while General Monk was expected every minute in the camp to which he did not return, a little Dutch felucca, manned by eleven men, cast anchor upon the coast of Scheveningen, nearly within cannon-shot of the port. It was night, the darkness was great, the tide rose in the darkness; it was a capital time to land passengers and merchandise.

The road of Scheveningen forms a vast crescent; it is not very deep and not very safe; therefore, nothing is seen stationed there but large Flemish hoys, or some of those Dutch barks which fishermen draw up on the sand on rollers, as the ancients did, according to Virgil. When the tide is rising, and advancing on land, it is not prudent to bring the vessels too close in shore, for, if the wind is fresh, the prows are buried in the sand; and the sand of that coast is spongy; it receives easily, but does not yield so well. It was on this account, no doubt, that a boat was detached from the bark, as soon as the latter had cast anchor, and came with eight sailors, amidst whom was to be seen an object of an oblong form, a sort of large pannier or bale.

The shore was deserted; the few fishermen inhabiting the down were gone to bed. The only sentinel that guarded the coast (a coast very badly guarded, seeing that a landing from large ships was impossible), without having been able to follow the example of the fishermen, who were gone to bed, imitated them so far, that he slept at the back of his watch-box as soundly as they slept in their beds. The only noise to be heard, then, was the whistling of the night breeze among the bushes and the brambles of the downs. But the people who were approaching were doubtless

mistrustful people, for this real silence and apparent solitude did not satisfy them. Their boat, therefore, scarcely as visible as a dark speck upon the ocean, glided along noiselessly, avoiding the use of their oars for fear of being heard, and gained the nearest land.

Scarcely had it touched the ground when a single man jumped out of the boat, after having given a brief order, in a manner which denoted the habit of commanding. In consequence of this order, several muskets immediately glittered in the feeble light reflected from that mirror of the heavens, the sea; and the oblong bale of which we spoke, containing no doubt some contraband object, was transported to land, with infinite precautions. Immediately after that, the man who had landed first, set off at a rapid pace diagonally towards the village of Scheveningen, directing his course to the nearest point of the wood. When there, he sought for that house already described as the temporary residence—and a very humble residence—of him who was styled by courtesy king of England.

All were asleep there, as everywhere else, only a large dog, of the race of those which the fishermen of Scheveningen harness to little carts to carry fish to the Hague, began to bark formidably as soon as the stranger's steps were audible beneath the windows. But the watchfulness, instead of alarming the newly-landed man, appeared, on the contrary, to give him great joy; for his voice might perhaps have proved insufficient to rouse the people of the house, whilst, with an auxiliary of that sort, his voice became almost useless. The stranger waited, then, till these reiterated and sonorous barkings should, according to all probability, have produced their effect, and then he ventured a summons. On hearing his voice, the dog began to roar with such violence that another voice was soon heard from the interior, quieting the dog. With that the dog was quieted.

'What do you want?' asked that voice, at the same time weak, broken, and civil.

'I want his majesty King Charles II, king of England,' said the stranger.

'What do you want with him?'

'I want to speak with him.'

'Who are you?'

'Ah! *Mordoux!* you ask too much; I don't like talking through doors.'

'Only tell me your name.'

'I do not say that either, monsieur. The welfare of my country before everything. God, who has given me the power, has, no doubt, willed that I should have that power for the good of all, and He has given me, at the same time, discernment. If the parliament were to order such a thing, I should reflect.'

The brow of Athos became clouded. 'Then I may positively say that your honour is not inclined to favour King Charles II?'

'You continue to question me, monsieur le comte; allow me to do so in turn, if you please.'

'Do, monsieur; and may God inspire you with the idea of replying to me as frankly as I shall reply to you.'

'When you shall have taken this money back to your prince, what advice will you give him?'

Athos fixed upon Monk a proud and resolute look.

'My lord,' said he, 'with this million, which others would perhaps employ in negotiating, I would advise the king to rise two regiments, to enter Scotland, which you have just pacified: to give to the people the franchises which the revolution promised them, and in which it has not, in all cases, kept its word. I should advise him to command in person this little army, which would, believe me, increase, and to die, standard in hand, and sword in sheath, saying, "Englishmen! I am the third king of my race you have killed; beware of the justice of God!"'

Monk hung down his head, and mused for an instant. 'If he succeeded,' said he, 'which is very improbable, but not impossible—for everything is possible in this world—what would you advise him to do?'

'To think that by the will of God he lost his crown, by the good will of men he recovered it.'

An ironical smile passed over the lips of Monk.

'Unfortunately, monsieur,' said he, 'kings do not know how to follow good advice.'

'Ah, my lord, Charles II is not a king,' replied Athos, smiling in his turn, but with a very different expression from Monk.

'Let us terminate this, monsieur le comte,—that is your desire, is it not?'

Athos bowed.